

Apurva Bhatnagar, PhD

New Delhi, India — +91-9654904885 — apurvabhatnagar26@gmail.com — LinkedIn

Profile

Development economist with eight years of experience working on health, nutrition, and social development programs in India and across South Asia, Southeast Asia, and Africa. Much of this work has been in direct partnership with Indian state governments, helping them understand how programs are performing and where they should focus resources. Equally comfortable doing the quantitative analysis and presenting findings to senior officials and making the case for what the data shows. Research has directly shaped government guidelines in Delhi, informed budget priorities in Uttar Pradesh, and influenced program design across the Philippines and Cambodia.

Skills

Research and Evaluation: Randomised controlled trials, process evaluations, survey design, sampling, power calculations, results frameworks, mixed-methods research.

India Expertise: Direct advisory partnerships with central and state governments on health, nutrition, and social programs; Indian administrative data systems; public finance analysis.

Data Analysis: Expert proficiency in Stata and R; building data pipelines, constructing indicators, and producing data visualisations for non-technical audiences.

Project Management: End-to-end management of complex multi-country projects; senior government and NGO partner engagement; team mentoring and capacity building.

Experience

- IDinsight** **2021 – Present**
Development Economist / Technical Manager *India and Global*

Selected Projects:

State Scheme and Budget Review – Government of Uttar Pradesh **2024 – 2025**

Co-lead, Analytical Team

Uttar Pradesh, India

- Co-led an analysis examining how well state-level central schemes are reaching intended beneficiaries in UP, and whether the state's budget allocation and spending patterns are aligned with its one trillion dollar economy target.
- Mapped gaps between scheme design and on-the-ground delivery across key sectors; developed recommendations for where the state should redirect resources to close those gaps and accelerate progress toward its development goals.

Early Warning System for School Dropouts – British Asian Trust and DCPCR **2023 – 2024**

Technical Lead, Algorithm Design

New Delhi, India

- Worked with the British Asian Trust and Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights to build a system that identifies children at risk of dropping out of school before it happens, enabling targeted support to reach them early.

- Developed the screening algorithm using available school and household data, carefully calibrating it to minimise both over-identification (flagging children who do not need help) and under-identification (missing children who do), so that limited intervention resources could be directed where they would matter most.

Anemia Mukht Bharat – Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights

2021 – 2023

Technical Lead, Process Evaluation

New Delhi, India

- Worked with Delhi's child rights commission to understand why the state's iron and folic acid supplementation program was reaching nearly all students in some schools and fewer than half in others, despite consistent supply at the state level.
- Surveyed 900 students across 26 schools and interviewed state officials, principals, and teachers to trace where the delivery chain was breaking down. Found that the problem was not resources or motivation but the complete absence of any standardised school-level procedure.
- Recommendations were adopted as state guidelines by Delhi's Directorate of Education in March 2023, now covering 1.6 million students.

Health Promotion and Literacy Study – Philippine Dept. of Health

2023 – Present

Technical Lead, Longitudinal Panel Study

Philippines

- Lead technical manager on a five-year nationally representative panel study tracking health knowledge, attitudes, and behaviour across 4,600 households in 17 regions of the Philippines, designed to inform Philippine DOH program and investment decisions.
- Designed the sampling strategy and indicator framework, managed data quality across biannual rounds, and produced evidence briefs translating results into recommendations for DOH program priorities.
- Led a dedicated study on mental health literacy, combining a nationally representative survey with 50 in-depth interviews with health officials and community members; findings fed into national mental health policy.

StrongMinds Uganda – Impact Evaluation of Mental Health Intervention

2026 – Present

Technical Lead, RCT

Uganda

- Leading the design of a randomised controlled trial evaluating the impact of StrongMinds' group mental health program on depression, anxiety, and functional wellbeing outcomes in Uganda. Responsible for the pre-analysis plan, randomisation strategy, power calculations, and outcome measurement framework.
- Developed the study theory of change, specifying the causal pathway from intervention delivery to changes in psychosocial outcomes, identifying the key assumptions to test, and determining the statistical conditions under which the trial would produce credible estimates of program impact.

Nutrition Impact Evaluations – CHAI and Nutrition International

2023 – 2025

Technical Lead, Evaluation Design

India and Philippines

- Designed pre-analysis plans and survey instruments for randomised and pre-post evaluations of nutrition programs; built indicator frameworks for dietary diversity and consumption outcomes and translated results into recommendations for program scale-up decisions.

Portfolio Technical Oversight – IDinsight

2025 – Present

Junior Economist II / Technical Manager

Global

- Provide analytical oversight across IDinsight’s health, nutrition, and agriculture project portfolio. Review and quality-check outputs to ensure findings are credible and framed in a way that is useful for decision-makers.
- Established organisation-wide coding standards in R; mentored junior researchers on evaluation methods and communication of results. Developed IDinsight’s institutional guidelines on using AI tools for qualitative research.

Research and Information System for Developing

2018 – 2021

- **Countries (RIS)**

Research Assistant

New Delhi, India

- Conducted policy research on trade and health policy; facilitated high-level dialogues between government ministries, industry leaders, and international organisations.
- Led a qualitative field study in Sichuan, China, on market integration policies for the indigenous medicine sector.

- **Afghanistan Employment Research – ILO**

2017 – 2018

Research Assistant to Dr. Anirban Dasgupta, Consultant

- Analysed household survey data on employment trends in post-conflict Afghanistan; co-authored ILO working papers informing reconstruction policy.

Education

- **Ph.D., Economics**

2019 – 2025

- *Jawaharlal Nehru University*

Income mobility and inequality in India

- **M.Phil., Economics**

2017 – 2019

- *Jawaharlal Nehru University*

- **M.A., Development Economics**

2015 – 2017

- *South Asian University*

Select Publications

1. Bhatnagar, A. (2023). Income mobility across castes in India. *Indian Economic Review*, 58(1), 45–72.
2. Dasgupta, A., Anhal, R., & Bhatnagar, A. (2019). Employment Scenario in Afghanistan. *ILO Asia Pacific Working Paper Series*.
3. Jeong, M., Huang, C., Hipol, M., Bhatnagar, A., et al. (2024). Process evaluation of Cambodia’s Early Grade Learning Program. VVOB Education for Development.